Date Pudding with Salted Caramel

FROM NELL'S KITCHEN

Rich with dates, warm spices and carob molasses, this is a comforting pudding made for sharing.

Serves 12–16 · Prep 25 min · Cook 50 min

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PUDDING

- 2½ cups pitted dates, chopped
- 2 tsp baking soda
- Approximately 2 cups boiling water, enough to just cover the dates in a snug bowl
- 1 cup butter, softened, plus extra for greasing
- 1 cup brown sugar
- 3 eggs
- 1 tbsp vanilla essence
- 4 tbsp carob molasses
- 3 cups plain flour
- 1 tbsp ground cinnamon
- 2 tsp ground ginger
- 2 tbsp baking powder
- 1 tsp sea salt flakes

FOR THE SALTED CARAMEL

- 50 g butter, cut into pieces
- 1 cup sugar
- ¾ cup crème fraîche, brought to room temperature
- ¼ tsp sea salt flakes

METHOD

1. Soak the dates. Place the chopped dates and baking soda in a heatproof bowl. Pour over the boiling water, stir and leave to soak for 1 hour. Keep the soaking liquid.
2. Prepare the tin. Preheat the oven to 175°C. Grease a deep 23 × 33 cm baking dish with butter.
3. Mash the dates. Mash the softened dates into their soaking liquid with a fork or potato masher, leaving a little texture.
4. Make the batter. Beat the softened butter and brown sugar until light and fluffy. Add the eggs one at a time, beating after each addition. Mix in the vanilla and carob molasses.
5. In a separate bowl, whisk together the flour, cinnamon, ginger, baking powder and sea salt flakes.
6. Fold the dry ingredients into the butter mixture in batches, alternating with the date mixture and its liquid. Mix just until combined.
7. Bake. Pour into the prepared dish and smooth the surface. Bake for approximately 40–50 minutes, checking from 40 minutes, until the centre is set and a skewer comes out without raw batter.
8. Make the salted caramel. While the pudding bakes, place the sugar in a heavy-based saucepan over medium heat. Let it melt, gently swirling the pan as needed, until it becomes an even amber colour.
9. Reduce the heat and carefully stir in the butter. Gradually add the crème fraîche, a spoonful at a time, stirring carefully as the caramel will bubble and release steam. Stir over low heat until smooth, then add the sea salt flakes.
10. Finish the pudding. Let the baked pudding stand for approximately 5 minutes, then prick the surface with a skewer. Spoon some warm caramel over the top, allowing it to soak in.
11. Serve warm, with the remaining salted caramel alongside.

Tip

Keep the date-soaking liquid. It goes into the batter with the softened dates.